

The Gender Gap Is a Subtraction

Fifty-two years of party identification, the one number everybody quotes, and the two numbers underneath it

84-355 Democracy's Data

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In 1972 the General Social Survey asked Americans which party they identified with. Men came out +28.4 net Democratic. Women came out +29.7.

Fifty-two years later the same question, asked the same way, returns -6.4 for men and +7.6 for women. The difference between those two numbers is 14.0 points, and that difference has a name. **The gender gap** is one of the most-quoted numbers in American politics.

It is also a subtraction. Somebody computes a number for women, computes a number for men, and prints the gap between them. What almost never gets printed is the pair.

01 Before you read on

In 1972 men and women were within a point and a half of each other, both about 29.7 points net Democratic. Today the gap between them is about 14.0 points.

Which side moved, and by how much? Give a number for each.

Write both numbers down.
Most readers get the direction
of one of them wrong.

02 Where this comes from, and why it is the GSS

Everything below is the General Social Survey cumulative file, release 3a: 75,699 respondents interviewed between 1972 and 2024, weighted with `wtssps`.

The GSS is here partly because it is right for the question and partly because it is the one that opens. A fifty-two-year series on an unchanged question is exactly what a claim about change requires, and the confidence chapter explains why that consistency exists at all.

The other reason is less flattering to the field. **Two better-known sources would answer this question and neither can be fetched by a script.** The American National Election Studies sits behind a registration page. The Cooperative Election Study sits on Harvard Dataverse, which answers an automated request with a success code and an empty body, a refusal this book's survey access chapter measures directly. The GSS hands the file to anybody who asks.

That is a fact about access rather than about quality. It decides which survey a student can actually work with, which is a different thing from which survey is best, and the difference is worth noticing every time it happens.

03 The one number

Here is the gap, drawn the way it is usually drawn.

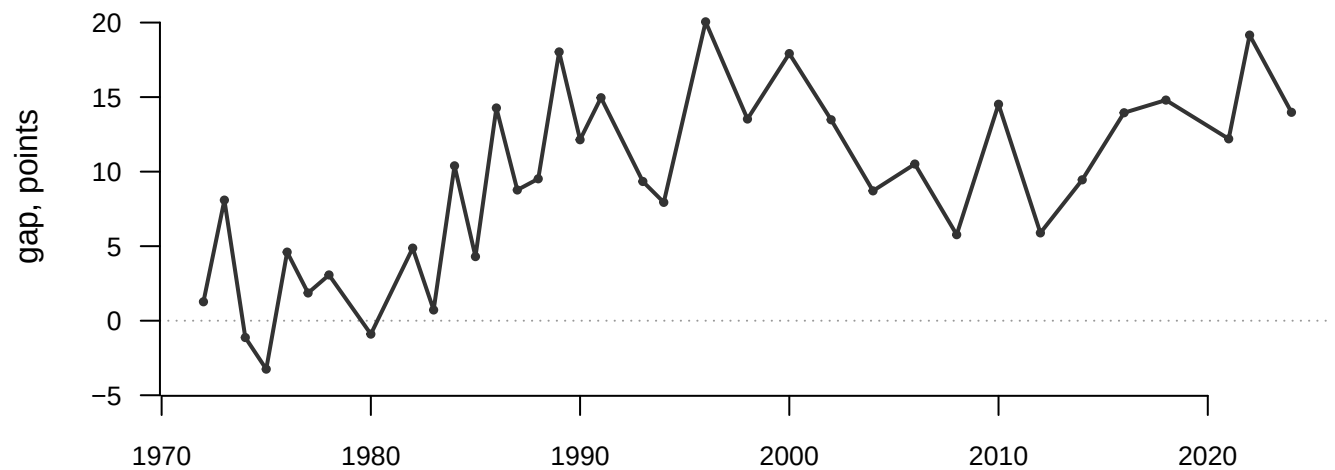


Figure 1. Women's net Democratic identification minus men's, every GSS year from 1972 to 2024.

It starts near zero. It widens through the 1980s, peaks at 20.1 points in 1996, and sits at 14.0 today.

Read that figure and one story suggests itself so strongly that most people do not notice they have supplied it. The gap opened, so **women must have moved left**. Nothing in Figure 1 says that. Nothing in Figure 1 can.

04 The two numbers

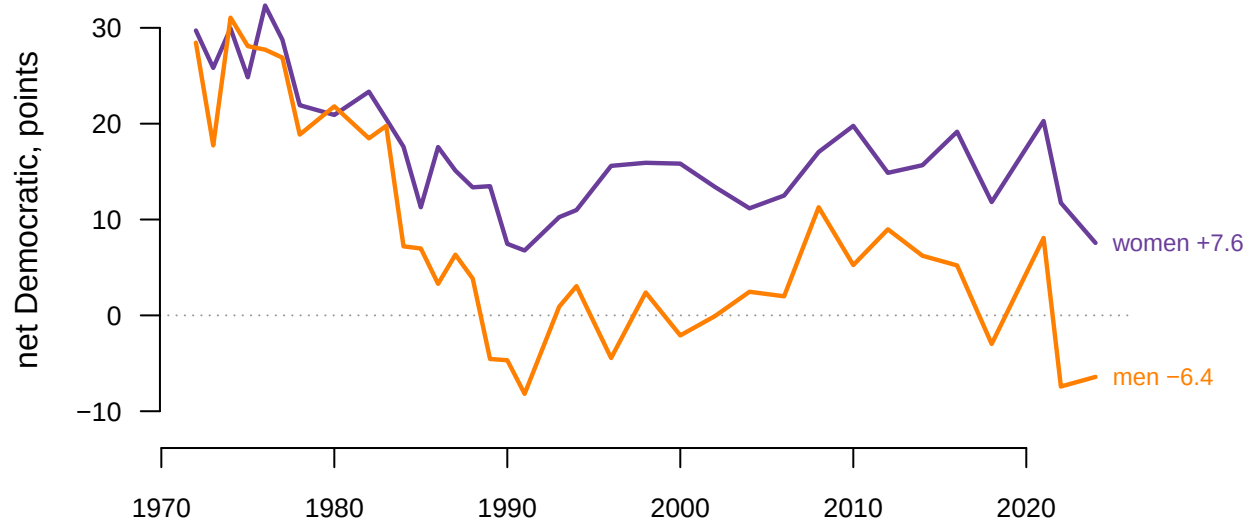


Figure 2. The same years, with the subtraction undone. In the browser, the buttons switch between the two series and the gap alone.

Both lines fall. Men went from +28.4 to -6.4, a move of 34.9 points. Women went from +29.7 to +7.6, a move of 22.2.

Women did not become more Democratic. They became less Democratic, by more than twenty points. The gap opened because **men moved 1.57 times as far in the same direction.**

Decade	Years	Men	Women	Gap
1970s	7	+25.5	+27.6	2.1
1980s	9	+9.2	+17.0	7.8
1990s	6	-1.8	+11.2	13.0
2000s	5	+2.7	+14.0	11.3
2010s	5	+4.5	+16.3	11.7
2020s	3	-1.9	+13.2	15.1

The decade averages say the same thing more slowly. Every column falls. The last one rises because the first two fall at different speeds.

05 Why this matters beyond one number

A gap is a difference, and a difference discards the level. Two series moving together by twenty points and two series moving apart by twenty points can produce the identical gap, and no amount of care in reporting the gap will recover which happened.

That is not a fault in the gender gap. It is a property of every difference this book reports, and several of them run the same way. The turnout chapter reports a gap between what people say and what they did, and that gap shrank while both of its halves moved. The cost of voting chapter ranks states against each other, which is a difference by construction, and its levels are not comparable across years at all.

Ask for the pair. It is one extra number and it changes the sentence.

06 A second subtraction, larger than the first

Split women by marital status and a bigger gap appears inside the smaller one.

Group	Net Democratic
Unmarried women	+19.1
Married women	-5.4
Unmarried men	-2.5
Married men	-9.1

In 2024, unmarried women were +19.1 and married women -5.4. That is 24.5 points between two groups of women, against 14.0 points between women and men.

The split inside the category is wider than the split between categories. Anybody reporting one number for women is averaging across a difference larger than the one they are reporting.

07 What this chapter cannot tell you

sex here is two boxes. The GSS records sex, not gender identity, and for most of this series it was coded by the interviewer. The file gained a different item, `sexnow1`, which was asked in 2021-2022 of 7,455 respondents. That is too few years to carry a fifty-two-year comparison, so it is counted here and not used. Nothing in this chapter speaks to people for whom the two items differ.

Party identification is not a vote. It is what somebody says they are, not what they did, and the two come apart. Whether the leaners belong with the party they lean toward is a decision this chapter made. The party identification chapter takes it apart, and finds the same choice moving a headline number by a factor of five.

These are cross-sections, not the same people. A series that falls can fall because individuals changed their minds, or because the people who held the old view died and were replaced. Nothing here separates those, and they are different countries.

The composition of each group changed underneath the line. “Women” in 1972 and “women” in 2024 differ in education, marital status, race and age. Some of the movement in Figure 2 is those compositions changing rather than anybody’s politics.

And a gap is not an explanation. This chapter shows which side moved. It does not say why, and the literature on why is large and unsettled.

08 What it does establish

Both sexes moved away from the Democratic Party across this series. Men moved 34.9 points and women 22.2, in the same direction, on the same question, weighted the same way.

The gap between them grew from 2.1 points in the 1970s to 15.1 in the 2020s. **Every point of that growth is a difference in speed, not a difference in direction.**

And the most-quoted version of the number hides that completely, because one line cannot show two movements.

09 Sources

- **General Social Survey**, cumulative file, release 3a (2024), NORC at the University of Chicago. 75,699 respondents, 1972-2024, weight `wtssps`. <https://gss.norc.umd.edu/en/gss/get-the-data.html>
- **Build.** `data/build-data.R` downloads the 47 MB zip, reads nine columns out of the 570 MB Stata file, and writes the small tables this chapter reads. The source is not committed; the derived tables are. Every number above is computed at the moment this document was rendered.
- **Related chapters.** Party identification on the leaner decision; confidence in institutions on the same file and the same weight; survey access on why this is the GSS and not the CES.

Checks

The data itself

Every figure above is drawn from these tables. They are plain CSV, they open in a spreadsheet, and they are yours to take further.

`by_decade.csv`, `partyid_by_sex.csv`, `partyid_by_sex_marital.csv`

Your turn

None of these is answered above, and every one can be answered from the tables you just opened.

- `partyid_by_sex.csv` has `men` and `women` separately, and the `gap` between them. Plot all three. Which of the two lines is doing the moving?
- `partyid_by_sex_marital.csv` splits the same people again by marital status. Compare the gap between married and unmarried women against the gap between women and men. Which subtraction is bigger?
- `by_decade.csv` collapses the series into decades. Compare it against the year-by-year file. What does the smoothing hide?
- `partyid_by_sex.csv` carries `n_men` and `n_women` for every year. Find the thinnest years. Would you report a gap that size off a sample that size?

Check	Passed
the Stata file is where this script expects it	yes
the whole cumulative file arrived, not one wave	yes
every row carries the weight this chapter uses	yes
the newer item covers a small minority of the file	yes
the series is continuous enough to draw	yes
no year rests on fewer than a hundred of either	yes
both series move in the same direction across the series	yes
the gap is wider at the end than at the start	yes
the 1970s gap is small and the 2020s gap is not	yes
the marriage split among women is not smaller than the sex gap that year	yes

REBUILD THIS DATA YOURSELF, WITH AN AI ASSISTANT

I want to rebuild a public dataset from its original source, without any starting files. Please do the following and show your work.

THE SOURCE. NORC at the University of Chicago, General Social Survey cumulative data file, release 3a, covering every survey from 1972 to 2024. One zip, about 47 MB, published at

https://gss.norc.org/content/dam/gss/get-the-data/documents/stata/GSS_stata.zip

No account or key is needed. Inside is a single Stata file, about 570 MB unpacked, with 75,699 rows and 6,943 columns. Each row is one person NORC interviewed, in whatever year they were interviewed. You will need software that can read a Stata file.

HOW TO FETCH IT. The server sometimes turns away plain scripted downloads. If a script is refused, download the zip in an ordinary browser and start from the file – it is the same object either way.

WHAT TO BUILD.

1. For every survey year, the net Democratic identification of men and of women, weighted with the WTSSPS weight: the weighted share who identify as or lean Democratic (PARTYID codes 0, 1, 2) minus the share who identify as or lean Republican (codes 4, 5, 6). Code 7, "other party", belongs to neither side; drop it. The gender gap is the women's number minus the men's.

2. A count of the respondents dropped as "other party", and a count of the respondents ever asked the newer SEXNOW1 gender question.

CHECK YOUR WORK. The copy this book used was fetched in August 2026.

If your rebuild matches it, you should find:

- 75,699 respondents in the file, 1972 through 2024
- 73,696 of them with both a sex and a usable party identification
- 1,375 dropped for naming another party
- 7,455 ever asked the newer gender question, all in 2021 and 2022

NORC issues a new release every year or two; if the file at that address has grown, the numbers changed because the data were extended or revised, not because you made an error.